

four walls to see where he should suspend the baby's hammock. Or, he would have to go to the stores in the shopping district to buy balls of yarn, or he would return with a big basket full of articles to sell. Or, he would go to his farm to read children's stories, because when his boy became inquisitive, he would have to know many things to tell him.

No, he wouldn't like to have his son be a King. He would be satisfied if the child were not born with the soul of a hireling. He certainly did not want that. He would never wish to see his son as he himself had been once, living discontentedly amidst men at the beck and call of masters.

It was night. Don Ponciano was waiting outside his shop, trembling between anxiety and joy, thinking of the son who would soon disturb the neighborhood with his bellows. Inside, moans, voices of women, suggestions, running around, jostling. Suddenly the moans stopped. The voices of the women became hushed. Their breathing was almost audible. And then, without warning, a wail! That plaintive cry which he felt under his dirty shirt like a flash of lightning.

And Ponciano Cruz bent his head in the shadow, and smiled in silence, more jubilant than ever before in his whole life.

VENTURA GARCIA CALDERON

The Lottery Ticket

Ventura García Calderón was born in Lima, Peru, in 1881. Son of a former Peruvian president, he has lived mainly in Paris, trying to interpret abroad South American culture. He has published in many magazines, but chiefly in *La Prensa* of Buenos Aires. His important works are *Frivolamente*, *Bajo el Clamor de las Sirenas*, and *La Venganza del Condor*. In Paris he published a well-known anthology of Hispano-American stories. [Used by permission of the translator, Richard Phibbs; first published in English by The Golden Cockerel Press, London.]

YOU HAVE HEARD THIS STORY BEFORE? No matter, I will tell it again because it points to a moral, and, better than that, to a state of mind. Also it is not without present-day interest.

The dancer, whom we will call Cielito, was the loveliest Spanish "bailadora" of about fifteen years ago, though not in the fashion of Madrid, where the taste in women at that time was Turkish—for fat all over. She was the Medici Venus, not the Milo—which measures three feet eleven inches round the hips.

You remember Cielito's version of the rumba, with a pink-tipped finger pointing to Heaven; and how the public used to roar for one

more look; and how she allowed it, just for one second, smiling like an angel fallen in the worst Gomorrah? If you have not seen Cielito dance the rumba, you do not know tropical love. In her dancing she played instinctively the cruel game of rousing lust and leaving it. Like the Persian butterfly, she was always playing with fire without ever getting burnt.

Cielito learned to dance in the West Indies, where this story takes place. The "danse du ventre" is a bourgeois family spectacle beside this swinging of the breasts. Breasts fit to be molded into beautiful cups, or like coupled doves to be caressed. The impish wanton shawl follows the swinging game, and at last, for a too brief unforgettable instant, is thrown aside.

One loses one's head when one speaks of Cielito; which would hardly surprise her, for there is not a woman in the world who knows more about men than she does.

Once when she was touring in Cuba she drove the men so mad that they had to have a lottery for her. Yes, a singular idea, but not really so strange in South America, where we leave everything to chance, even the pretty women. Well, in this distant town of the island of sugar cane and honey, the spectators were able one night to buy with their theater tickets the chance of taking Cielito away with them after the performance. Only one spectator could win of course, but in the crowds at the booking-office every man was Don Juan looking with hatred at his possible rival, the neighbor who was also buying the right to be the happiest of men.

Even Cielito was a little moved when the evening came, and there was something almost chaste in her languorous glances at the audience who riotously refused any other music-hall items. They only wanted Cielito with her shuffling false-negro steps and very soft creole words "arza columpiate." But there were no passionate encores, no one asked Cielito to carry her perversity any further. Everyone was in too great a hurry for the draw, which was very correctly carried out, like a family lottery, on the stage itself.

A top hat was filled with numbered place-slips, and the draw was presided over by the theater manager; rather pale and nervous, for any suspicion of trickery would have been punished on the spot, and there's no knowing what may happen when a lot of violent men are after the same girl. Believe me it was more than mere lust for a beautiful woman; you have no idea how much magic and romance is attached to any European actress by South Americans dreaming of Montmartre and Andalusia. A Frenchwoman is all Paris to them, a Spaniard is Seville or Granada with the chirrup of grasshoppers in the sunshine. These phantasies are a sort of feverish mental stimulant to our people, and a beautiful body does not help to lessen the fever.

At exactly midnight the winning number, 213, was called by a man in evening dress who had turned his back on the hat and unhesitatingly drawn a slip of paper.

The whole room looked for the winner, some mocking voices called for him to go up on the stage so that everyone could see him before he went into the wings with Cielito.

No one answered, and there was an expectant silence. A spectator who had come very near success jogged the elbow of his neighbor in seat 213, almost forcing him to rise.

He was a fine looking negro, "a bit of ebony" the conquistadores would have called him; "black as sin" the old women say even now. He rose slowly with the charming comic solemnity of the colored people, whose vain smile fitly answers the amused glances of the crowd. With deliberate slowness he looked through his note-case for the ticket, found it at last in a greasy envelope, and tore it up into very small pieces which he threw in the air like confetti before the astounded audience.

That ample gesture ought to have made his refusal clear enough. But the people could not believe he was rejecting Cielito, the finest flower of Spain. So he shook his head, looking grave and sulky, but enjoying very much the displeasure he was causing.

All the bitterness of the subject races was in him, all the misery of his ancestors who had died as slaves among the sugar cane. The hot joy of revenge burned on his obstinate coal black face as he disdained what so many white men had dreamed about with longing. Then with a shrug of his shoulders, very dignified and sure of his importance, he prepared to leave the theater, while from the stage Cielito with her hands on her hips in a truly Spanish fury spat out at him her shame and her disgust.

But there was no need of a word from her. The whole audience rushed on the black man and began to beat him. So he did not want the flower of Spain—he was disgusted with the darling of Andalusia—they would show him—they would finish him.

It was a most unlooked for lynching, unknown no doubt in the United States where they don't yet punish the abstemious negro who refuses to "outrage" a white woman.

Half an hour afterwards they sent the dying man to hospital; and, as they have given up drawing lots for Cielito, I will not bother you with the address of the theater.